

No laughing Business

PHOTOGRAPHER: Mexy Xavier, IMAGING: Atul Deshmukh

Be it accounts, stock-taking, or the all-important payrolls, Nola can take 'em all on

The flexibility, stability and the power that Linux offers makes it a unanimous OS choice for business applications throughout the world. However, a long-established notion is that you need specialised software to get a grip on accounting, payroll and such taxing tasks when using Linux systems. And perhaps advertise for an 'experienced system administrator' who, though glum, is quite glib at keeping the system going.

Meet Nola, a software that helps you makes sense of all that *moolah* math with minimum effort. The best part is that it's PHP Hypertext Preprocessor (PHP)-based, so once you set it up on the server, all client machines can access it, irrespective of the OS they are running. Further, PHP lets you customise it in minutes, with just the basic knowledge of this famous server-side scripting language.

What you need

Nola is an open-source software that's written in PHP, and uses MySQL as its database. Distributed under General Public License (GNU) license, and developed by Noguska Management Systems, it's approximately 5 MB in size. Download it from <http://nola.noguska.com/>.

It takes quite a while to install, courtesy its many dependencies. Here's a detailed list of them: Apache 1.3.21, OpenSSL 0.9.6b, Mod_SSL 2.8.4, Libjpeg 6b, Libpng 1.0.11, Tiff 3.5.6-beta, GD Library 1.8.4, Mhash 0.8.9, LibMcrypt 2.4.15, Mcrypt 2.5.7, PDFLib 4.0.1, Zlib 1.1.3, PHP 4.0.6 and MySql 3.23.4.1. That's pretty exhaustive, but in normal cases, you won't have to worry about anything except PHP, Apache and MySQL—all of which you need to configure before installing this suite.

Let's get started

Ensure that you have PHP, Apache and MySQL installed on your Linux system. If you did a complete install, these components are already installed. Check this in Red Hat Linux 9 by going to **K menu > System Settings > Add / Remove Applications** to start the Package Manager. Under the Server, check Web Server and click Details. Enable all the checkboxes, and click OK. Now, enable the SQL Database Server and click Details. Click OK after enabling all the checkboxes. To finish, click Update. Enter the Red Hat 9 installation CDs when it asks to complete the update. Don't worry about the other components, since they are installed by default.

Nola comes as a tar ball named *nola-1.1.2.tar.gz*. Extract this file to */var/www/html*—the default root directory.